

## TRADITIONAL TRADES

“Skills become livelihoods.”

---

Not every economy is built in a field. Some livelihoods begin with a hand, a tool, a thread, a leaf, a piece of wood, a metal surface or a skill learned from another generation. A craft can be small in scale and still be important. It can provide household income. It can supply everyday objects. It can preserve knowledge. And sometimes, it can turn local materials into something valuable enough to enter a market.

Continuing the economic progression from land (Page 47) and livestock (Page 48), Page 49 examines traditional economic skills and craft-based livelihoods associated with Orakzai. While subsistence agriculture and animal husbandry form the bedrock of the rural economy, traditional trades provide essential household utensils, textile expressions, and supplementary income that sustain mountain communities.<sup>14</sup>



“Linear economic transformation from local raw materials to household livelihood and market exchange.”

WHAT IS A TRADITIONAL TRADE?

A traditional trade is an economic activity whose skills, techniques, materials or occupational practices have been transmitted across generations or maintained within a community. Traditional does not automatically mean ancient, unchanged, purely handmade, or economically dominant. A traditional trade can adapt to new materials, markets, and technologies while retaining its foundational techniques.<sup>34</sup>



“Differentiating physical production (craft) from commercial distribution (trade) to form a sustainable livelihood.”

ORAKZAI HANDICRAFT EVIDENCE

Documented source material specifically identifies three traditional handicraft and economic activities associated with the Orakzai district: household items produced from mazri palm leaves, traditional embroidery on garments, and historical silkworm raising. These activities reflect the resourcefulness of mountain households in utilizing indigenous flora and sericulture.<sup>12</sup>

| CRAFT CATEGORY   | PRIMARY MATERIAL  | DOCUMENTED PRODUCTS                       | EVIDENCE LEVEL               |
|------------------|-------------------|-------------------------------------------|------------------------------|
| Mazri Palm Craft | Mazri Palm Leaves | Baskets (*Shkor*), Mats (*Musalah*), Fans | Orakzai-Specific [1] [2] [5] |
| Embroidery       | Thread & Textiles | Garments and household textiles           |                              |

| CRAFT CATEGORY   | PRIMARY MATERIAL    | DOCUMENTED PRODUCTS           | EVIDENCE LEVEL              |
|------------------|---------------------|-------------------------------|-----------------------------|
|                  |                     |                               | Orakzai-Specific [1]<br>[3] |
| Silkworm Raising | Silkworms & Cocoons | Silk fibre and yarn           | Orakzai-Specific [1]        |
| Woodwork         | Timber & Pine       | Furniture and structural wood | Regional Comparison [1]     |



## MIXED LIVELIHOODS & SEASONAL ECONOMY

Rural households in Orakzai rarely rely on a single economic activity. Instead, they combine agriculture, livestock raising, traditional trades, wage labour, and seasonal migration into a diversified livelihood strategy. During intensive farming seasons, labour is directed toward fields; in off-seasons, household members engage in craft production, processing, and repair. This flexibility ensures resilience against environmental and economic shocks.<sup>14</sup>

WHAT WE KNOW — AND WHAT WE DO NOT

While official records document mazri palm crafts, embroidery, and silkworm raising in Orakzai, quantitative economic output data for these trades remains limited. Crafts primarily serve household utility and local market exchange rather than industrial-scale export, functioning as an essential supplement to agrarian and pastoral income.

#### AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

A hand that holds a plow can also weave a palm leaf. In our mountains, survival has always required more than one skill. When winters close the high passes and fields rest under frost, our homes remain active. Through thread, palm, and patience, our people have turned what the earth provides into things of utility and beauty. These trades are the quiet threads that bind our households together across generations.

---

**“The skill of the hand sustains the spirit of the home.”**

#### AUTHOR'S SYNTHESIS

---